

Burkina



The west African state of Burkina was known as Upper Volta until 1984. It became a multiparty state in 1991, though former military ruler Blaise Compaoré remains in power.



GEOGRAPHY

The Sahara covers the north of the country. The south is largely savanna. The three main rivers are the Black, White, and Red Voltas.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Dry, cool weather November–February. Erratic rain March–April, mostly in southeast.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

No single ethnic group is dominant, but the Mossi, from around Ouagadougou, have always played an important part in government. The people from the west are much more ethnically mixed. Extreme poverty has led to a strong sense of egalitarianism. Most women are still denied access to education, though their absence from public life belies their real power and social influence.



THE ECONOMY

Cotton is the major cash crop, but the encroaching Sahara Desert is restricting agriculture. Beneficiary of foreign debt cancellation plans.



INSIGHT: Droughts and poor soils mean that many Burkinabes seek work southward in Ghana and Côte d'Ivoire



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Burkina Faso

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Ouagadougou

POPULATION: 15.8 million

TOTAL AREA: 105,869 sq. miles
(274,200 sq. km)

DENSITY: 149 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Mossi, Fulani, French*, Tuareg, Dyula, Songhai

RELIGIONS: Muslim 55%,
Traditional beliefs 35%, Roman Catholic 9%,
other Christian 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Other 52%, Mossi 48%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes